

PAGE 7 — THE ATLANTIC WAR IN CANADA

Bell Island and a Continental System

The Battle of the Atlantic in a Continental Context

“The Battle of the Atlantic was not a distant naval campaign, but a continental system extending from Canadian industry and communities to the open ocean—reaching as far inland as Port Arthur (now Thunder Bay) on Lake Superior, near the geographic centre of North America.”

The Battle of the Atlantic was sustained by an interconnected system linking Newfoundland and Canada to the North Atlantic. Naval operations at sea depended on a network of ports, airfields, industrial centres, and communities on land. From the iron mines of Bell Island to the shipyards of Quebec and the factories of Ontario, and westward to the agricultural production of the Prairie provinces and resources of British Columbia, materials were transported east by rail through the Lakehead at Port Arthur and Fort William (now Thunder Bay) before moving onward to Atlantic ports for shipment overseas. Together, these elements formed a continuous chain connecting Canadian resources and industry directly to the conduct of the war at sea.

Newfoundland and Labrador

Forward Edge of the Atlantic War

During the Second World War, Newfoundland and Labrador occupied a position of exceptional strategic importance at the eastern edge of North America. As a separate Dominion administered by Britain, it served as a forward base for Allied naval and air operations, forming the western gateway to the North Atlantic convoy system.

St. John's

At St. John's, the war was both operational and visible. The port functioned as a forward assembly and escort base at the western edge of the North Atlantic. Ships formed up there to shorten their exposure to submarine attack, concentrate escort forces, and depart under protection into the Atlantic convoy system, allowing formation closer to the open ocean, reducing transit time in vulnerable waters, and ensuring immediate escort coverage.

At **Signal Hill National Historic Site**, wartime installations supported observation, signalling, and coastal defence, while at **Cape Spear National Historic Site**—the easternmost point in North America—coastal artillery batteries protected the harbour approaches. Additional gun positions, radar stations, and observation posts around the Avalon Peninsula formed a layered defensive system safeguarding this critical port.

Naval Operations

Naval operations formed the core of Newfoundland's role in the Atlantic war. From St. John's and Argentia, Royal Canadian Navy and Allied escort groups operated into the North Atlantic, protecting merchant shipping moving between North America and Britain. These ports functioned as forward operational bases within the convoy system, enabling escort vessels to deploy directly into the western Atlantic approaches.

St. John's served as a critical escort staging point, supporting corvettes, destroyers, and auxiliary vessels tasked with convoy protection. Escort groups joined convoys shortly after departure, reducing the distance ships travelled without protection and strengthening the defensive structure of the convoy system at its most vulnerable western edge.

Argentia, developed as a major Allied naval base, complemented this role by supporting repair, refuelling, and broader fleet operations. Together with Halifax and Sydney, these facilities formed an integrated network through which convoys were assembled, escorted, and routed across the Atlantic.

Air Operations

Air operations formed a parallel and equally critical system. Airfields at Gander, Torbay, and Goose Bay supported trans-Atlantic ferry operations, long-range maritime patrols, and anti-submarine warfare. These bases enabled the movement of aircraft from North America to Britain while extending air coverage over the North Atlantic and Gulf of St. Lawrence.

At **Gander**, long-range ferry aircraft—including bombers such as the Consolidated B-24 Liberator and transport aircraft—staged for flights eastward across the Atlantic via Greenland and Iceland before reaching Britain. The base functioned as a critical hub in the North Atlantic ferry route, enabling the continuous movement of aircraft to European theatres while also supporting maritime patrol operations over adjacent ocean approaches.

At **Torbay** (near St. John's), Royal Canadian Air Force squadrons operated maritime patrol aircraft such as the Lockheed Hudson and, later, the Consolidated PBY Canso flying boat. From this base, aircraft conducted coastal reconnaissance, convoy escort, and anti-submarine patrols over the approaches to the Avalon Peninsula and the entrance to the Gulf of St. Lawrence, providing early warning and protection for shipping assembling at St. John's.

At **Goose Bay**, aircraft operating along the northern ferry route departed west-to-east toward Greenland, Iceland, and onward to Britain, forming a key link in the trans-Atlantic air bridge. The base also supported reconnaissance and patrol operations over the Labrador Sea and

northern Atlantic approaches, contributing to both the ferry system and the surveillance of northern maritime routes.

In Labrador, although fixed coastal defences were limited, the region played an important role in air operations and weather monitoring. In 1943, the German Kriegsmarine, using the submarine *U-537*, secretly established Weather Station Kurt on the Labrador coast—the only German military installation in North America during the war—reflecting the importance of meteorological data to naval and air operations. The station remained undiscovered until 1977 and is now preserved at the Canadian War Museum.

Outport Communities and the Lived Atlantic War

Beyond major centres, communities such as Twillingate and Fogo Island formed part of the wider operational landscape of the Atlantic war. Positioned along the northeastern approaches to Notre Dame Bay and the open Atlantic, these communities lay within the movement corridors of coastal shipping, naval patrols, and convoy traffic linking Newfoundland to the wider North Atlantic system.

While not major bases, their geographic position placed them within a network of observation, communication, and maritime awareness extending across the island. Residents lived with the constant presence of the war at sea—ships passing offshore, patrol aircraft overhead, and the knowledge that submarine activity had reached nearby waters. In this sense, the Battle of the Atlantic was not confined to ports and bases, but experienced across coastal communities where civilian life and naval operations intersected.

Today, places such as Twillingate and Fogo Island provide an important cultural and geographic perspective on the Atlantic war, illustrating how global conflict was embedded within local landscapes and lived experience.

Bell Island

Bell Island formed a critical industrial component of the Atlantic war system and stands as one of the most concentrated and visible expressions of that system in North America. Iron ore mined at Wabana supplied steel production in Sydney and in Britain, linking a single industrial site directly to Allied shipbuilding, armaments production, and the broader conduct of the war at sea.

The harbour at Wabana became a regular anchorage for ore carriers operating within the North Atlantic convoy network. Ships loaded in sight of the island before departing under escort into the Atlantic, physically connecting resource extraction, transportation, and naval operations within a single landscape.

In 1942, German submarines penetrated Conception Bay and attacked these anchored vessels, sinking four merchant ships within sight of shore. These attacks represent the only known instance of repeated U-boat strikes within the same harbour in North American waters and remain one of the clearest examples of the Atlantic war reaching directly into an industrial port.

What distinguishes Bell Island is the integration of its surviving elements. The wrecks lie offshore within diving depth, while on land the iron mines, coastal defences, and community landscape remain accessible and legible. Together, these features form a unified wartime environment in which industrial production, naval operations, and civilian life intersected. In this sense, Bell Island is not only a site of wartime loss, but a rare, intact representation of the Atlantic war as a complete system.

The Crow's Nest Officers' Club

At Crow's Nest Officers' Club, the social and operational world of the Battle of the Atlantic is preserved in a form found almost nowhere else. Established in 1942 as a private club for Allied naval and merchant marine officers passing through St. John's, it provided a controlled environment where officers from different services and nations could exchange information and decompress between convoy operations. Closely tied to St. John's role as a forward convoy base, the club became an informal extension of the operational network. Its interior remains largely unchanged from the wartime period, containing original furnishings, ship plaques, artifacts, and memorabilia linked directly to vessels and crews engaged in the Atlantic war, and it continues to operate as a private club rather than a reconstructed museum.

Battle of the Atlantic Trail

1. Cape Spear National Historic Site – St. John's
2. Signal Hill National Historic Site – St. John's
3. Crow's Nest Officers' Club – St. John's
4. The Rooms – St. John's
5. Admiralty House Communications Museum – Mount Pearl
6. Bell Island Community Museum – Bell Island
7. No. 2 Mine Tour and Museum – Bell Island
8. Lance Cove Seamen's Memorial – Bell Island
9. North Atlantic Aviation Museum – Gander
10. Gander Aviation Museum – Gander
11. Botwood Flying Boat Museum – Botwood
12. Goose Bay Military Heritage Museum – Goose Bay

Nova Scotia

Convoy Assembly, Naval Command, and Air Operations

Nova Scotia formed the operational centre of Canada's Atlantic war effort and one of the principal hubs of the Battle of the Atlantic.

Halifax – Naval Operations

In **Halifax**, convoys assembled in **Bedford Basin** before departing for Britain. Halifax served as the principal convoy assembly port and a central command hub for the Royal Canadian Navy, coordinating escort groups, routing merchant shipping, and sustaining continuous transatlantic operations. Shipping from across North America—including vessels arriving from the United States and Caribbean routes carrying oil, bauxite, and other critical materials—was integrated into this system, with Halifax functioning as the primary assembly point for transatlantic crossings.

This role was supported by a substantial naval infrastructure centred on **HMCS Stadacona**, the Royal Canadian Navy's principal shore establishment, and **HMC Dockyard Halifax**, which provided repair, maintenance, and logistical support to escort vessels and convoy traffic. These facilities enabled the rapid turnaround, refitting, and redeployment of ships operating within the Atlantic convoy system.

From Halifax, the Royal Canadian Navy directed operations in the **Northwest Atlantic** under the command of Rear-Admiral (later Vice-Admiral) Leonard W. Murray from 1943 to 1945. His command extended across the western North Atlantic—from the eastern seaboard of the United States and Canada, from New York northward—into mid-ocean, encompassing the Gulf of St. Lawrence, coastal waters, and key convoy routes. This represented the only theatre of the Second World War under the operational command of a Canadian officer.

Convoys assembling in Bedford Basin represented one of the most concentrated and organized groupings of naval and merchant shipping in the Atlantic war. At peak periods, dozens of vessels—merchant ships, corvettes, destroyers, and auxiliary craft—were anchored in close proximity before departure. This concentration required precise coordination, including routing, signalling, scheduling, and strict harbour control measures governing all vessel movements.

Halifax – Integration of Naval, Air and Coastal Defence Systems

Halifax's effectiveness depended on the integration of naval, air, and coastal defence systems. Royal Canadian Navy escort groups operating from the port worked in coordination with Royal Canadian Air Force patrol aircraft based at nearby airfields, extending protective coverage over convoy routes as they entered and departed the western Atlantic. Coastal artillery positions and harbour defences secured the approaches to the port, including fortifications at **McNabs Island** fortifications, **Georges Island National Historic Site**, **Point Pleasant Park** fortifications, and **York Redoubt National Historic Site**, which together formed a layered defensive system controlling access to Halifax Harbour. This system was further supported by radar installations, examination services, and communications networks that monitored and regulated all vessel movements entering and leaving the port.

Sydney – Convoy Assembly Point and Industrial Centre

Further north, **Sydney** functioned as both a convoy port and a major industrial centre. Steel production in Sydney, supplied in part by iron ore from **Bell Island**, supported shipbuilding and

war production in Canada and abroad, linking Nova Scotia directly to the industrial and logistical chain sustaining the Atlantic war. Sydney also served as a secondary convoy assembly and routing port, particularly for slower or coastal convoys, where vessels could form, regroup, and depart under escort into the North Atlantic. Its position at the entrance to the Gulf of St. Lawrence made it an important staging point linking inland shipping to the wider convoy system.

Air Operations

Air operations formed a critical extension of the Atlantic war system, linking coastal defence to mid-ocean convoy protection. From Royal Canadian Air Force stations at CFB Shearwater (**RCAF Station Dartmouth**) and CFB Greenwood (**RCAF Station Greenwood**), maritime patrol aircraft conducted reconnaissance, anti-submarine warfare, and convoy escort operations over the western Atlantic and the Gulf of St. Lawrence.

From RCAF Station Dartmouth (Shearwater), aircraft such as the Stranraer, Canso, and Hudson conducted coastal patrol and anti-submarine operations, while from RCAF Station Greenwood, long-range aircraft including the Liberator extended convoy protection into the mid-Atlantic. Together, these operations reduced the vulnerability of shipping by detecting and tracking submarine threats and by extending protective coverage beyond coastal waters.

At **Shearwater Aviation Museum**, the Royal Canadian Air Force's role in the Battle of the Atlantic is interpreted through maritime aircraft such as the Swordfish and Avenger, alongside operational exhibits reflecting the work of Eastern Air Command. In the Annapolis Valley, **Greenwood Military Aviation Museum** reflects the role of long-range patrol aircraft in extending convoy protection into the open Atlantic. At **Atlantic Canada Aviation Museum**, aspects of this history are presented within a broader regional aviation context, including aircraft associated with maritime patrol and naval aviation.

HMCS *Sackville*

At HMCS *Sackville*, Canada preserves the last surviving Flower-class corvette, the vessel that formed the backbone of Allied convoy escort forces during the Battle of the Atlantic. Commissioned in 1941, HMCS *Sackville* served on North Atlantic escort duties, protecting merchant convoys against submarine attack.

Today, the vessel is maintained as **Canada's Naval Memorial**, commemorating the service and sacrifice of the Royal Canadian Navy, the Merchant Navy, and the Royal Canadian Air Force. Restored to its wartime configuration, the ship allows visitors to experience the bridge, gun platforms, engine room, and crew spaces, providing a direct and immersive connection to the conditions of convoy escort operations.

HMCS *Sackville* was formally recommissioned into the Royal Canadian Navy on May 15, 2026, the 85th anniversary of her launch, as a ceremonial and heritage vessel recognizing her role as the last surviving Flower-class corvette and a symbol of Canada's naval contribution to the Battle of the Atlantic.

Battle of the Atlantic Trail

1. Maritime Museum of the Atlantic – Halifax
2. Naval Museum of Halifax – Halifax
3. HMCS *Sackville* – Halifax
4. York Redoubt National Historic Site – Fergusons Cove (Halifax)
5. Georges Island National Historic Site – Halifax Harbour
6. McNabs Island (coastal defence fortifications) – Halifax Harbour
7. Halifax Memorial – Halifax
8. Merchant Navy Memorial – Halifax
9. Point Pleasant Park (coastal defence fortifications) – Halifax
10. Shearwater Aviation Museum – Dartmouth
11. Atlantic Canada Aviation Museum – Goffs (Halifax)
12. Greenwood Military Aviation Museum – Greenwood
13. Merchant Mariner Monument – Sydney
14. Cape Breton Miners' Museum – Glace Bay

Prince Edward Island

Training and Air Operations Support

Prince Edward Island contributed to the Battle of the Atlantic primarily through the training system and air operations that supported the Royal Canadian Air Force.

At Summerside, **RCAF Station Summerside** operated under the British Commonwealth Air Training Plan, training aircrew who would later serve in operational units conducting maritime patrol and anti-submarine missions in the North Atlantic and Gulf of St. Lawrence.

In addition to its training role, airfields on Prince Edward Island supported broader Royal Canadian Air Force activities associated with coastal surveillance and regional air operations during the Battle of the St. Lawrence (1942–1944), contributing to the wider aerial defence network protecting shipping in the Gulf.

The Royal Canadian Navy did not maintain major operational bases on Prince Edward Island during the war. However, naval forces operated in surrounding waters, and the island formed

part of the wider maritime environment in which coastal shipping, convoy movements, and anti-submarine operations were conducted.

Battle of the Atlantic Trail

- Former RCAF Station Summerside – Summerside
-

New Brunswick

Defence of the Gulf of St. Lawrence

New Brunswick formed part of the defensive network protecting the Gulf of St. Lawrence, which became an active combat zone in 1942 as part of the wider Battle of the Atlantic.

In New Brunswick, the Royal Canadian Navy focused on harbour defence, coastal patrols, and training, particularly in Saint John and St. Andrews, contributing to the protection of regional shipping and supporting operations in the Gulf of St. Lawrence during the Battle of the St. Lawrence.

During the **Battle of the St. Lawrence (1942–1944)**, the Royal Canadian Air Force played the dominant role in anti-submarine operations from bases in the province, including **Chatham** and **Moncton**. From these airfields, RCAF units conducted maritime patrols and reconnaissance over the Gulf and adjacent inland waters, working in coordination with naval and coastal defence forces.

During this period, German U-boats sank approximately twenty-three vessels and damaged others in the Gulf of St. Lawrence and the lower reaches of the river. These attacks brought the war directly into Canadian inland waters, disrupting coastal shipping and highlighting the vulnerability of regional supply routes linking Atlantic Canada to central Canada.

Although New Brunswick did not host major coastal artillery complexes comparable to those in Newfoundland or Nova Scotia, its ports, airfields, and training facilities formed an important component of a broader defensive system extending along the eastern seaboard.

In New Brunswick, commemoration of the Battle of the Atlantic is most clearly expressed through memorials rather than large museum institutions, with major sites in Saint John and

Moncton, while locations such as Miramichi reflect the province's operational role through former Royal Canadian Air Force bases.

Battle of the Atlantic Trail

1. New Brunswick Naval Memorial (Plaza Maris) – Saint John
 2. Battle of the Atlantic Memorial Anchor – Moncton
 3. Miramichi (RCAF Station Chatham) – Miramichi
-

Quebec

Industry, Air Defence, and the Inland War

Quebec linked inland industrial production to the Atlantic war effort through a sequence of regions extending along the St. Lawrence River.

The Saguenay–Lac-Saint-Jean region formed one of the most important industrial foundations of the Allied war effort in Canada. Like the iron ore mines of Bell Island, aluminum production in this region—derived from imported bauxite and supported by large-scale hydroelectric development—was essential for aircraft construction. The strategic importance of this industrial system was reflected in the establishment of air facilities at CFB Bagotville, originally established during the war as **RCAF Station Bagotville**, forming part of the broader defensive network protecting eastern Canada's industrial infrastructure.

The St. Lawrence River itself became a theatre of war in 1942, when German U-boats penetrated the lower river, operating as far inland as the approaches to Anticosti Island and the **Rimouski** sector. During the Battle of the St. Lawrence (1942–1944), U-boats sank approximately twenty-three vessels and damaged others, heightening concern over the security of coastal shipping and industrial supply routes along this major shipping corridor.

Along the Gaspé Peninsula, coastal defence installations and bunker remains reflect efforts to protect the approaches to the St. Lawrence River. Some of these remains are located within or near **Forillon National Park**, where elements of wartime coastal defence infrastructure can still be seen along the shoreline.

Further west, shipyards at Lévis—including the **Davie shipyard**—and Quebec City supported naval and merchant vessel construction and repair, forming an important component of the industrial network connecting the lower St. Lawrence to the wider convoy system.

At Montreal, aircraft production was led by **Canadian Vickers**, which manufactured Canso flying boats used extensively by the Royal Canadian Air Force in maritime patrol and anti-submarine operations during the Battle of the Atlantic, supported by other regional manufacturers producing transport and training aircraft for the broader war effort.

Today, institutions across the province, including the museum at RCAF Station Bagotville (now CFB Bagotville), interpret this history, including the Battle of the St. Lawrence and the wider Battle of the Atlantic.

Battle of the Atlantic Trail

1. Forillon National Park – Gaspé
 2. Site historique maritime de la Pointe-au-Père – (*furthest confirmed U-boat operations; site includes HMCS Onondaga, a preserved RCN submarine*)
 3. Bagotville Air Defence Museum – CFB Bagotville
 4. Naval Museum of Quebec – Quebec City
-

Ontario

Industrial Production and Naval and Air Force Expansion

Ontario represented the western extent of the Atlantic war system, linking industrial production, manpower, and transportation networks to operations in the North Atlantic.

Steel production in Hamilton supported shipbuilding and broader industrial output, while shipyards at Midland, Collingwood, Toronto, Kingston, and Port Arthur constructed corvettes, minesweepers, and auxiliary vessels for the Royal Canadian Navy. These vessels were deployed to Atlantic waters as part of Canada's expanding naval contribution to the war.

At **HMCS York Naval Reserve Division**, thousands of personnel were recruited and trained for naval service, reflecting the importance of inland Canada in sustaining the fleet.

Aircraft production formed a parallel and important component of the war effort. At Downsview, **de Havilland Canada** manufactured Mosquito aircraft. While primarily employed in bombing and reconnaissance roles, the Mosquito also served in maritime operations with Coastal Command, contributing to the wider air war over the Atlantic.

The Royal Canadian Air Force's role in the Battle of the Atlantic is reflected in preserved aircraft across the province. At the **Canadian Warplane Heritage Museum**, the Canso flying boat is presented in the markings of No. 162 Squadron RCAF, whose aircraft operated from Iceland and Scotland in anti-submarine operations during the Battle of the Atlantic. The aircraft remains airworthy, and public flights are offered during the summer months, providing a rare opportunity to experience an aircraft type central to the air war over the Atlantic.

At the **National Air Force Museum of Canada**, aircraft associated with the Royal Canadian Air Force's role in the Battle of the Atlantic are interpreted through maritime patrol and anti-submarine types, including the Consolidated PBY Canso flying boat, the Lockheed Hudson, and the Consolidated B-24 Liberator—all of which were central to maritime patrol, convoy protection, and long-range anti-submarine operations across the North Atlantic.

At **HMCS *Haida* National Historic Site**, Canada's most famous destroyer reflects the operational reach of the Royal Canadian Navy in Atlantic and European waters.

Battle of the Atlantic Trail

1. Canadian War Museum – Ottawa
 2. Canada Aviation and Space Museum – Ottawa
 3. National Air Force Museum of Canada – CFB Trenton
 4. Former de Havilland Canada Aircraft Plant (wartime production hanger) – Downsview, Toronto
 5. HMCS *York* Naval Reserve Division (wartime recruiting and training centre) – Toronto
 6. HMCS *Haida* National Historic Site – Hamilton
 7. Canadian Warplane Heritage Museum – Hamilton
-

Illinois

The U-boat Campaign in Context

At Chicago's **Museum of Science and Industry**, the German submarine *U-505* is preserved within a purpose-built, climate-controlled underground exhibit designed specifically to protect and interpret the vessel.

The *U-505* exhibit is widely regarded as the most complete and best-interpreted U-boat display in the world. Unlike many surviving submarines, which are displayed outdoors or in partial form, *U-505* is preserved as an intact vessel within a controlled environment that allows for both conservation and immersive interpretation.

The exhibit presents multiple dimensions of the Battle of the Atlantic. It interprets the 1944 capture of *U-505* by the United States Navy—one of the few instances in the war in which a submarine was seized intact at sea—and places this event within the broader context of anti-submarine warfare. The display also examines U-boat technology, including propulsion systems, torpedoes, communications, and the operational conditions under which submarine crews operated.

Equally important is the human dimension. The exhibit conveys life aboard a German submarine, including confined living conditions, operational demands, and the challenges faced during extended patrols in the North Atlantic. Through this approach, the display presents the U-boat campaign as part of a wider naval conflict involving multiple nations and services.

As a preserved vessel, *U-505* provides a direct and tangible perspective on submarine operations during the Battle of the Atlantic, forming a fitting western endpoint to a continental system that began with resources and industry in Canada and extended to the open ocean.

Battle of the Atlantic Trail

- Museum of Science and Industry – Chicago (*U-505 Submarine Exhibit*)

A Continental War System

The Battle of the Atlantic was sustained not only at sea, but across a network of regions, industries, and communities extending deep into North America. From Bell Island to the Great Lakes, this network linked natural resources, industrial production, and military operations in a continuous chain supporting the Allied war effort. Seen in this context, the Atlantic war was not a distant naval campaign, but a continental enterprise rooted in Canadian landscapes and carried outward to the open ocean.